was still not in a position to conduct a nuclear test that would provide enough information for a proper deterrent. [32]

In the late 1970s and 1980s, financial, political, bureaucratic and technological factors played a role in impeding the nuclear programme, as did international circumstances and tighter export controls. All of this resulted in India's nuclear quest progressing only in fits and starts. By the end of the Cold War, India was in a difficult position. While its nuclear programme had made considerable progress and had successfully detonated a nuclear device, India effectively faced two nuclear-armed states in China and Pakistan. At the same time, it found itself outside the nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) and faced export controls and various international technology denials. The challenge that India consequently faced by the early 1990s was to achieve a sufficient nuclear deterrent against China and Pakistan while deriving access to civilian nuclear technology and reintegrating into the international nuclear architecture.

Uneasy Terms: India and China, 1974–1991

The 1962 Sino–Indian Border War had been a disaster for India, one that cast a long shadow on India's confidence, reputation, and overall outlook. But it is also possible that India may have overlearned some of those lessons. The 1967 skirmishes near Sikkim were one case in point. That sector was further transformed by India's annexation of Sikkim in 1975. Sikkim had been a British protectorate and that status had transferred to relations with the Republic of India in 1950. It had its own flag and currency under its hereditary leader, the Chogyal, but its defence and foreign policy were India's responsibility. In 1973, popular agitations for democratic rule began against the last Chogyal Palden Thondup Namgyal. In response to growing agitations, the Indian Army intervened. A vote in the Sikkim's Parliament and a referendum conducted in the presence of Indian forces in April 1975 showed overwhelming support for joining India, and within a month the Indian Constitution was amended to make Sikkim a